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'TRIBES' AND THE AFTERMATH OF THE CHILEMBWE RISING¹

LANDEG WHITE

I

IN THE LAST week of January 1915, Milthorpe, the assistant resident and magistrate in the sub-district of Chiradzulu, was a deeply nervous man. On the night of Saturday 23 January, he had been absent in Blantyre at the home of Mrs Byrne when, in the rising led by John Chilembwe, three whites in the sub-district had been killed, including W. J. Livingstone, general manager of A. L. Bruce Estates. Although it was known that Milthorpe had been warned by an askari on the Friday night that there were 'men with spears' talking under the mountain, he was hoping to persuade his superiors that he was not at fault. Meanwhile, in a district overrun with private armies and with Chilembwe himself still uncaptured, he found himself quite alone in the residency. Though he corresponded three times a day with Moggridge, the resident in Blantyre, and with the planters at Midima, he felt isolated and vulnerable. It was a relief when the Yao chiefs and headmen of the district presented themselves at his office. Every day they brought him assurances that they did not support Chilembwe and that he personally was in no danger. They courted him with gifts of eggs, flour and chickens and Milthorpe responded. He found he liked talking to them ('I am giving all the chiefs a feed') and did not resent the time they took up. He liked their Islamic robes, so different from the disturbing mimicry of the suits worn by Chilembwe and his followers. Several of them wore skull caps, which obviated the embarrassments of hat-raising posed by African Christianity. While four days running the sound of the dynamite used to destroy Chilembwe's church at Mbombwe echoed back from the mountain, Milthorpe wrote categorically that Mpama, Malika, Chikoja, Onga, Kadewere and the others were all completely loyal.

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1. These footnotes refer with few exceptions to material held in the Malawi National Archives (MNA) and the Public Record Office, London (PRO), and to Oral Testimony (OT) collected by myself in Zomba and Chiradzulu Districts in 1982 and by other members of the Zomba History Project as cited. I owe, however, a large debt to earlier writers on the Chilembwe rising, in particular, G. S. Mwase, *Strike a Blow and Die* (Harvard, 1967), G. Shepperson & T. Price, *Independent African* (Edinburgh, 1958), I and J. Linden, 'John Chilembwe and the new Jerusalem', *African History* 12, (1971), pp. 629-51, and D. D. Phiri, *Malawians to Remember: John Chilembwe* (Longman: Malawi, 1978). In broader terms I am indebted to the writings of Martin Chanock, Kings Phiri, Leroy Vail and Megan Vaughan.

Kadewere in particular was proving helpful with information about the rebels' whereabouts.²

The chiefs and headmen also had good reasons to be anxious. However ambiguous their feelings had been about the revolt, they were keen to disassociate themselves from its failure. They were, moreover, compromised. Though Chilembwe was a Christian, he was also a Yao. Several of them—Chikoja and Kadewere especially—had villages which lay along the route taken by Chilembwe's soldiers on the long hot Sunday when they had conducted the white women and children back towards Chiradzulu. Kadewere's men had given cloth to the soldiers, and though they had also given eggs to the *boma* askari there was a risk they might have got the equation wrong. It would be months before they were all cleared of suspicion of having assisted at the time and of having harboured Chilembwe's men subsequently, and they would have to listen to repeated harangues from Wade, Milthorpe's successor, that 'to our certain knowledge some of these natives had been fed and sheltered in their villages'.³ Behind these immediate anxieties were longer memories. The last time the district had seen military action on this scale, the battle lines had been drawn not between black and white 'christians' but between the administration and the Yao chiefs. Although the initial reason for the seizure of British Central Africa in 1891 had been to secure the territory from the Portuguese, it was the actions taken against the slave-trading chiefs which came to provide the moral justification for British actions, the consummation of Livingstone's dreams. Harry Johnston's wars of conquest in the Shire highlands and valley had been against relatives of the present chiefs: Mponda, Matapwiri, Zarafi, Nkanda and Chikumbu. His contempt for the Yao was legendary. Only a year or two back Alfred Sharpe, once Johnston's deputy in the wars, had stood with W. J. Livingstone on the verandah of Bruce's house at Magomero and asked 'if they were still the same lawless cut-throat men, whom he had occasion once to quell, who inhabited Chiradzulu'.⁴

By 1915, Sharpe's was a voice from the past. Even in his day men calling themselves Yao had formed the bulk of local recruits for the police force and the army, a 'change as sudden and remarkable as may be seen amongst the border tribes of India where the enemies of yesterday become the disciplined troops of the Imperial power today'.⁵ As the British administration consolidated its hold, the idea of incorporating chiefs and headmen into its bureaucratic structures had become increasingly attractive. There were

2. MNA COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence; evidence of Moggridge. NSB 7/3/2 Monthly Reports for Chiradzulu sub-district for Feb. and Mar. 1915 inc letters Milthorpe to Moggridge 27/1/15, 28/1/15, 30/1/15, 2/2/15 and 4/2/15.

3. MNA, NSB 7/3/2, Report of 10/4/15. COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence; evidence of Kadewere. PRO CO 525/62, Smith to CO 21/6/15.

4. MNA S1/3008/23, Kathy Livingstone's reply (Typescript, n.d.). District Books, vols 1 for Zomba, Blantyre & Mulanje.

5. *British Central Africa Gazette* (hereafter BCAG), 15/1/96.

numerous problems—tax collection, immigration, afforestation, labour recruitment, and village crime—for which they were better equipped by knowledge and prestige to deal, and in 1912 the passage of the District Administration (Native) Ordinance looked forward to the days when this possibility might become a reality. Although the new Ordinance remained an aspiration, the chiefs were increasingly pressurised. Yet until the aftermath of the Chilembwe rising, older beliefs and assumptions still ruled. In Chiradzulu in 1911, 'one of the chief crimes' was still 'slave-trading'. In January 1913 one of Milthorpe's predecessors asked advice about a slavery case. A Yao headman named Kumlanjira had kidnapped an 'Anguru' girl until her husband discovered her whereabouts. Kumlanjira beat him up but the girl escaped. The query was whether any offence had been committed and Moggridge's reply from Blantyre was unambiguous: slavery cases were to be treated with the utmost seriousness:

I was talking to an old Nguru man a short time ago about this country and Portuguese territory; he said he would not go back for anything and when I asked him what was the principal difference now that there is no *nkondo* there, he pointed to a group of children standing near the road a quarter of a mile from their village and looking at us and said, 'You would not see that over there, the first passerby would steal them'.⁶

This, though, was virtually the last time that the term 'Yao' would be associated in the administration's mind with slavery or that the term 'Anguru' would attract such humanly consideration.

II

The first Nguru people to enter the Shire highlands were present there in 1861 when a group settled under chief Mangasanja on the western side of the Ruvo river objected to the attempts of the UMCA missionaries to pass through their village southwards. By 1884, when they caused similar problems for John Buchanan seeking an eastwards route to Quelimane after the shooting of the Makololo chief Chipatula, the Nguru had been driven by the Yao back across the Ruvo to the land around Mount Mangulu, the origin of their name. They left behind in the Shire Highlands a habit among the British of calling all who crossed the border from Mozambique 'Anguru'.⁷

The migration of 'Anguru' peoples into British territory began in 1895 when, following the defeats of Kawinga, Matapwiri and Zarafi, a 'large influx of natives found its way into the Zomba District where', as the

6. MNA, NSB 7/3/1 Cruise to Moggridge 19/1/13. NSB 2/1/1 Moggridge to Cruise 20/1/13.

7. Details of these episodes are given in, e.g., N. R. Bennett and M. Ylvisaker, *The Central African Journal of Lovell J. Procter 1960-64* (Boston, 1971), and John Buchanan, *The Shire Highlands, East Central Africa as Colony & Mission* (Edinburgh, 1885).

British Central African Gazette noted, eyeing them covetously, 'they are peaceably settled in full assurance of freedom and immunity from slave-raiding'. Some of these people were slaves freed from the Yao chiefs' stockades, while others came from the country between Lake Chilwa and the Namuli Hills. They spoke Lomwe, Mpotola and Mihavani, but not Nguru. During the days of the slave trade they had taken refuge for a generation in tiny hilltop settlements, their groups living in relative isolation. But the defeat of the Yao warlords brought them down in search of land to settle and cultivate, and across the border into British Central Africa. By May 1897, the *Gazette* noted that 1000 Anguru were working in the Shire highlands compared to 9000 Ngoni and 2000 Atonga. A year later, when Ngoni labour was scarce, the deficit was filled by 'the large influx of Anguru which has taken place this year'.⁸

The standard British explanation for the 'Anguru' migration was that they were fleeing ill treatment by the Portuguese. The mass flight across the border in 1899 and 1900, however, was caused less by anything the Portuguese had yet done than by the activities of the Blantyre labour recruiters Sinderam and Walker. In 1899, these men were hired by the Governor of Quelimane to recruit 1500 carriers from the Namuli Hills, which no Portuguese army had yet subdued, for the expedition against the Yao chief Mataka. Sinderam and Walker accepted 'on condition that for one week the Governor gave them the necessary powers to deal with the tribes there'. It took them six days, their method being to approach each headman in turn with the words: 'Do you want peace or war? On the one hand we offer you a free tax paper and work for which you will be paid in cloth; on the other, War!' After the burning of an 'occasional hut', most people, they reported, 'took the sensible view'. They were 'ably' assisted by Hetherwick and John Gray Kufa of the Blantyre Mission in persuading the Lomwe to accept the terms offered. Sinderam and Walker's reward, conferred by Portugal Durão of the Companhia da Zambesia which leased the area in 1899, was an eighteen-month monopoly of labour recruitment in Portuguese Angoniland and Anguruland.⁹

The consequences became apparent the following year when in August Sinderam and Walker were prosecuted in Blantyre for importing Mozambican labourers to a compound in Ndirande without making provision for housing, food, sanitary or medical arrangements, and without reporting deaths. During the first nine months of their contract, they had 'recruited' 2000 Anguru carriers for the African Lakes Company alone, of whom 1948 ran away. When the first groups absconded Sinderam caught several on the road and took them to the compound at Mandala where they were flogged. The matter came to court because of protests from Blantyre

8. BCAG, 1/12/95, 1/5/96 and 15/5/97. *Central African Times* (hereafter CAT), 27/8/98.

9. CAT 7/10/99.

residents: James Reid of the Blantyre Mission saw thirty-five new graves at Mandala and Hetherwick found bodies in the mission compound while V. J. N. Cox, the planter, described graves along the road to Mpeso. On 21 July 1900 the *Gazette* published 'The Anguru Road: Gruesome Sights' describing a journey made by Wylie of the Blantyre Mission to Chiradzulu and Namadzi. Wylie saw graves along the roadside, half-eaten corpses in the bush and on river banks, and finally bands of fleeing Lomwe, men half-starved and suffering from dysentery, returning to their homes across the border. Sinderam and Walker were fined £250, including a £50 fine for the assaults at Mandala.¹⁰

Despite this fiasco, it was already clear that the 'Anguru' were, as the *Gazette* put it, 'a field worth cultivating'. As the white planters of the Shire highlands struggled with coffee, rubber, cotton and tea to find an exportable commodity, their main problem was labour. Although the mechanism of the hut tax had been devised in 1894 in part to solve this problem, it had proved in practice an inefficient device. Even when Africans could be induced to pay their tax in labour rather than in cash or kind, the hut tax generated only one month's work per man per year, which allowed no time for the development of skills, and it produced a labour surplus in the dry season but virtually no labour in the rains when decisions had to be made about the scale of the season's plantings. Moreover, once Africans had been induced to migrate in search of employment, they found it more profitable to leave the territory altogether in search of the higher pay available elsewhere in southern Africa. The extra-legal violence which accompanied labour recruitment in Ngoni areas, and the imposition of the labour certificate in 1901 which forced Africans to pay double tax if they chose not to work for a white, were both in different ways acknowledgements of the failure of hut tax in itself to mobilise labour. At bottom the Africans of Nyasaland had too many alternatives.¹¹

Across the border, however, it was precisely these alternatives which were being abolished. In 1899 a new labour code was introduced in Mozambique, abolishing the free labour market of earlier liberal regimes and stating that all male Africans between fourteen and sixty years of age were legally obliged to work. The head tax was raised to 1200 *reis*, making the total tax for a man and his wife 2400 *reis* plus 5 per cent additional for the city council, as compared to a *hut* tax of 3s (1050 *reis*) in British territory. Legislation directed against itinerant Indian traders conferred an effective monopoly of commerce on the company concession holders of Quelimane District, and in 1900, a year of appalling famine, the Companhia da Zambesia which owned the concessions for the 'Anguru'

10. CAT 14/7/1900 and 21/7/1900. BCAG 31/7/1900.

11. *Kings Regulations Published in the British Central African Protectorate 1894-1900 Inclusive* (Zomba, 1902) 24-5 and 60-1. B.C.A.G. 31/12/01.

prazos of Lomwe, Milanje and Lugella began levying labour for its coconut plantations near Quelimane. 'Anguru' in their thousands began pouring across the border into British Central Africa. They were greeted by the resident at Mulanje who handed out one-year tax exemption certificates to the new settlers.¹²

What made them so valuable was their vulnerability. As immigrants they lacked the right to settle and, in particular, they lacked land. By being offered land in return for labour they could be turned into a captive work force. Two groups took advantage of their vulnerability, the white planters and the established chiefs and headmen. It was the planters who had most land to offer.

A determining fact of the colonial history of the Shire highlands is that land alienation took place before the arrival of the colonial administration. The vast estates of A. L. Bruce, Eugene Sharrer (later British Central Africa Co.), the Buchanan brothers (later Blantyre & East Africa Co.), and the African Lakes Co., comprising almost one million acres in all, were obtained during the 1880s as part of the attempt to persuade the British government that the Shire highlands were a legitimate area of British concern and should be secured from the Portuguese. One of the reasons why this tactic was possible lay in the fact that the bulk of the land Buchanan and the others 'purchased' from the chiefs was relatively unoccupied. The UMCA missionaries in 1861 had found the Shire highlands thickly populated with Mang'anja villages. The Yao invasions, however, the expansion of the slave trade and the disastrous famine of 1862, had resulted in an entirely different pattern of settlement whereby the principal chiefs ruled from heavily fortified stockades on the mountain tops. Malemia was based on Zomba, Kawinga on Chikala, Mpama on Chiradzulu and Kapeni on Soche while Matapwiri occupied the strategic Fort Lister gap. The land between reverted to secondary forest and was by the 1880s thick with game, the general insecurity of the pre-colonial period being perpetuated by the Ngoni raids of 1880 and 1884. With the exception of some small estates in the Blantyre area and the estates secured by the African Lakes Co. in the Shire valley, it was this largely unoccupied and uncultivated land which became alienated in the 1880s. From then on the issue dominating the politics of colonial Nyasaland, at least in the southern region, was not the terms on which Africans could be driven from their ancestral lands but the terms on which they would be permitted to settle.¹³

12. Mlanje District Book, vol 1. See also Leroy Vail and Landeg White, *Capitalism & Colonialism in Mozambique: a Study of Quelimane District* (Heinemann Educational Books, 1980), esp. chapters 3 & 4.

13. M.N.A., District Books vols 1, Mulanje, Blantyre, Zomba. *Central African Planter* (C.A.P.) 12/5/97. *Chikowi Historical Texts*, collected by Kings Phiri with C. Chidzero and G. Maluza, nos 1, 3, 6, 7 etc. For a full account, see Megan Vaughan, 'Social & Economic Change in Southern Malawi: a study of Rural Communities in the Shire Highlands and Upper Shire Valley from the mid-nineteenth century to 1915', Ph.D. thesis, London 1981.

When 'Anguru' migrants began to cross the border, the planters thus had vast tracts of land available for settlement under the labour-rent or *thangata* system. In strictly legal terms, it promised to be as inefficient a way of mobilising labour as the hut tax had proved. According to the legislation of 1904, *thangata* workers were to be provided with eight acres of land for settlement and cultivation, the 'rent' on this land being one month's labour per year in lieu of hut tax plus one month's *thangata* labour paid at the current rate of the tax. In theory, then, the planter was required to exchange eight acres of land for two month's labour annually; to obtain a permanent labour force of 1000 men, necessary to run a small plantation, he would need to settle 6000 families on 48,000 acres. The attractions of the system, however, lay in the hidden advantages to the planters. Labour was supervised by the planters themselves or their capitiões. A month's hut tax labour could be stretched to six or eight weeks simply by withholding a signature from the tax certificate. *Thangata* agreements were verbal and informal and not in any case subject to investigation by the administration, so that most planters had little difficulty in extending the requirement to four or five months. Unlike hut tax or labour certificate labour, *thangata* labour could be levied in the rainy season. The 'Anguru' were in no position to bargain; if they refused to work or if they attempted, like other Africans, to seek work in South Africa or Southern Rhodesia, they lost their right to land in Nyasaland. Despite the Lands Ordinance of 1904, therefore, the planters encouraged the 'Anguru' to settle. A. L. Bruce, for example, explained to the commission of enquiry into the Chilembwe rising how labour was obtained for the Bruce Estates. Initially, the land being virtually unpopulated, he had been forced to open sixteen separate small plantations distributed around the borders of the estate to attract hut tax labour from crown land areas in Zomba and Chiradzulu. The settlement of immigrants, however, in villages dotted around the estate under Yao headman appointed by himself and paid to attract 'Anguru', had made the company self-sufficient in labour and had opened up the possibility of cultivating the interior.¹⁴

In 1912, the Colonial Office queried the wisdom of allowing so many to enter the protectorate. If immigration continued at the present rate, it was argued, crown land areas would become so congested that no land would be available for future British settlers, while the *thangata* system was so extravagant with land that no planters would be willing to sell portions of their estates. The curious blend of massive land alienation in the Shire highlands and massive immigration was a recipe for economic stagnation, and the government would lose revenue for rents as well as duties on

14. *Ordinances, Rules, Proclamations and Notices Promulgated in the British Central African Protectorate* (Zomba 1905), 10–11. M.N.A., COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence—evidence of A. L. Bruce.

trade. As for the 'Anguru', given that their low wages 'must be a record for any settled part of Africa', there were doubts about how long they 'will be content to work on the present terms'. Governor Manning's reply to this prophetic comment was reassuring. What the government had lost in rents it had gained in hut taxes which, in Mulanje district alone, had risen from 6137 taxes in 1901-02 to 20,010 in 1911-12. Without a railway to the coast, planters simply could not afford the wages necessary to attract and retain Angoni labour. 'Anguru' immigration had come 'most opportunely. It populated vacant spaces, it enhanced the Protectorate's revenue and most important of all it has provided a ready and permanent labour supply for the extension of European enterprise'. It had, however, 'almost ceased by 1912', and all fresh arrivals would be directed on to the estates.¹⁵

But the planters were not the only beneficiaries. As the 'Anguru' came across the border in groups of families or small villages, they settled first under the protection of chiefs and headmen in Mulanje district. Some moved on after a year or two to chiefs in Chiradzulu while others, often moving via a brief stay in Chiradzulu, were attracted by the offer of land to the private estates. The chiefs and headmen concerned were Yaos who had established themselves in the Shire highlands following the incursions of the early 1860s, and who, as already noted, lived with their followers in fortified stockades on the mountain tops. After Harry Johnston's conquests, people began to move down from the mountains and to cultivate the plain. In 1895 it was noted:

The defeat of the various Yao chiefs throughout the Shire highlands has had the effect of rendering a residence on the plains around Mlanje no longer a matter of perpetual danger to natives and many villages have therefore been vacated on the hillside of Mlanje and new ones built in the low countries.¹⁶

By 1904, settlement in Mulanje district had advanced as far as the Tuchila river and by 1912 the whole region was dotted with villages up to the Palombe river and the very borders of the A. L. Bruce Estates. Similarly, in Zomba district the people moved down from the plateau and by 1898 were cultivating land three miles from the mountain's base. In Chiradzulu, the land bordering the Mwanje river was still 'uninhabited' in 1907 when it began to be settled with villages. Colonial officials explained

15. P.R.O., C.O. 525/44, Manning to C.O. 2/11/12 with minute papers of Parkinson 23/12/12 and W.C.S. 23/12/12.

16. BCAG 1/6/95. Chikowi Historical Texts nos 17, 20 etc. O.T., interviews at Mpawa (9/7/82), Komiha (19/7/82), Bowadi (22/7/82), Mpotola (5/8/82) etc.

this move to lower ground in terms of security and especially in terms of the release of women from 'slave' marriages and the resurgence of matrilineal patterns of settlement. Oral testimony suggests a further reason: that the first colonial *bomas* were established in the mountains on the sites of the former stockades at Chikala, Chiradzulu and Fort Lister, and that the people simply moved away from them.¹⁷

To clear the plains for settlement by cutting down the trees which had grown since the 1860s required labour and it was the 'Anguru' who supplied it. In Mulanje district, immigrants were given food by the chiefs as *ganyāo* (bonus) for clearing fresh land. When the immigrants moved on into Chiradzulu or to the private estates, their successors either cleared further land or cultivated cotton under the chiefs' and headmen's supervision, cotton being the major cash crop from Mulanje until the rise of the tea industry created a demand for plantation labour. Similarly, in Chiradzulu district, once the forested land had been cleared 'Anguru' labour under the *ganyāo* system was used to produce maize and vegetables for sale in Blantyre. On the whole, the administration approved. The new settlements along the Tuchila river did sometimes lead to accusations of domestic slave-holding and slave-trading and one important Yao headman, Kada, was imprisoned in 1909. On the other hand, the chiefs were successful in getting cotton and food production under way and were useful in supplying *boma* labour. The consensus was that, although the 'Anguru' were 'kept in a certain degree of mild subjection and occasionally perform a little menial labour for the protection of the chiefs under whom they serve, there is no serious interference with their rights and duties'. This is probably a fair comment for although the 'Anguru' were vulnerable, they were not, at the most local levels, altogether without alternatives. They could choose between Mulanje and Chiradzulu and Zomba districts, or between crown land areas or private estates. On crown land they could choose between individual chiefs and headmen, with consequences of lasting significance; for, as we shall see, the chiefs who came to prominence in the colonial period were precisely those who attracted the largest number of settlers.¹⁸

In addition to the planters and the chiefs, however, there was a third group in the Shire highlands also involved in the production of crops for sale and also in need of labour. In August 1912, the sub-resident at Chiradzulu reported that he was being asked to sign the labour certificates of 'natives who are in the employ of other natives', adding ungrammatically that he was inclined to think

17. M.N.A. District Books vols 1 for Mulanje, Blantyre & Zomba. C.T., interviews by Megan Vaughan at Kabango village 2/2/78, Kapichi village, 19/5/78, Chikanda village 9/5/78 etc. *Chikowi Historical Texts* no 4.

18. Ibid. See also C.A.P. 12/5/97 and B.C.A.G. 29/11/97.

that these natives, who work for others, who are planting crops with fairly large acreages, and who are in part genuine native planters, should be allowed to pay their taxes at the reduced rate.¹⁹

Asked to supply details, he obliged with a list. There were what he called the Gordon brothers (in fact Gordon and Hugh Mataka) in part ownership with Duncan Njilima. These owned an estate of 250 acres and employed 50 workers. Their most recent crop was three tons of maize and just over four tons of tobacco which had been sold at prices up to fourpence three-farthings per pound, and they also owned several trading concerns in north-east Rhodesia. There was Duncan Njilima himself, farming with his brothers on thirty acres next door to the Gordon brothers at Nsoni. He was in difficulties, his cotton having failed, and there were complaints that his labour force of 20 had not been paid. Njilima possessed, however, a solid brick house as evidence of earlier success and he had a ton of tobacco currently for sale. There was John Chilembwe farming 93 acres at Mombwe. His cotton had also failed but he was selling foodstuffs locally. Most of his efforts were devoted to building a large church. Chilembwe was 'not a very trustworthy person', and there was evidence of some resentment at his mission that the 50 workers had to take employment elsewhere for one month to get their labour certificates signed. There was John Gray (Kufa), 'probably one of the best natives of this class', farming 140 acres at Nsoni. Gray employed 27 people and had cultivated 27 acres of cotton, 12 acres of maize and 50 acres of tobacco. He also had cattle, sheep, goats and an orchard of fruit trees. These were the most important of the group, although there were others, including retired capitôes and Gomani, an Ngoni headman, who was causing trouble by demanding *thangata* labour from settlers on his land. On the whole, it was felt that it would be a bad thing to allow these people to sign labour certificates: 'they will sign up all their relatives ticket free and take on boys for a week or so without pay to get their tickets signed'.²⁰

Potentially, as employers and small landowners, this group was in conflict with the chiefs and headmen as well as with the white planters. Reports that in November 1914 Chilembwe was baptising hundreds of 'Anguru' were not calculated to make him popular. As this indicates, though, the rivalry was rather more than a competition for labour. There was a growing conflict between Christianity, of which Chilembwe's mission and the African planters were the most prominent local expressions, and Islam represented by the Yao chiefs and headmen in informal alliance with the white planters. W. J. Livingstone destroyed one of Chilembwe's churches on the Bruce Estates and Bruce himself forbade the building of

19. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/1 monthly report for Aug 1912.

20. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/1 monthly report for Aug 1913 enc. 'Native Landowners and Lessees in Chiradzulu sub-district' 14/9/13.

mission schools. The Yao chiefs, too, had quarrelled with Chilembwe and Kadeware, who complained that 'John Chilembwe's people never respected me at all', and had burned down one of Chilembwe's schools. There were mosques in Kadewere's, Nkalo's and Onga's main villages, and there was also a mosque at Mkanje on the Bruce Estates. Most of the headmen chosen by Bruce to govern the villages in which 'Anguru' immigrants were being settled were Yao and Mohameddan. Though mission schools were banned there were schools on the Estates for teaching Swahili as well as informal classes held on the headmen's verandahs. To supervise the 'Anguru' at work, however, and to keep the labour records, Bruce, like the *boma*, needed capitões who were literate in English. For the most part they were Christian and, like Wilson Msimba and John Gray Kufa, former capitões turned planters; they were also members of Chilembwe's church.²¹

To fill out the background to the Chilembwe rising in this fashion is not to explain its causes. Despite the thousands of words written about him, Chilembwe remains the most elusive and private of persons. It has been possible to document his anger at African involvement in the First World War, his quarrel with the Bruce Estates, his concern over the predicament of 'Anguru' workers who took their complaints to him, and his resentment over the labour certificate issue, but no one can prove that these together or alone caused the rising. How far he was influenced by prophecies of Armageddon, how far affected by private debt and ill-health, how far persuaded that such a rising would win mass support and be successful, is problematical. His aims and actions passed into mythology the moment he died and without letters or diaries to reveal him to posterity the historian can only adjust the myths. The background does, however, throw light on the rising's aftermath as the authorities sought to explain and contain it. Most of the African planters of Chiradzulu were executed as were many of Bruce's field capitões. Most of the blame was put on the 'Anguru', the link between the different groups being Chilembwe's mission at Mbombwe. The main African beneficiaries were the Yao chiefs.

III

Something of the confusion of that last week of January 1915 can be deduced from the records of the magistrate's court in Zomba. After the surviving leaders of the rising had been tried and executed, some 1000 lesser cases were brought to trial of whom 547 were subsequently freed for lack of evidence. Some of these people had been arrested by askari, others

21. M.N.A., N.S.B. 2/1/2 Moggridge to Milthorpe 16/2/15. COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence, evidence of Kadewere, A. L. Bruce & A. L. Bruce recalled, and Mwalimu.

by the military or by a special contingent of Angoni levies. A volunteer force of planters had picked up some, as too had the chiefs and headmen and vigilante groups of ordinary villagers. Some were arrested by A. L. Bruce himself who went so far as to take statements at his home at Magomero, all of which were subsequently upheld. One man, a Mohammedan tailor called Gide, was arrested by Indian traders. To make an arrest was a declaration of loyalty to the administration and no one who did so found himself subsequently in trouble.

The criteria for arrest, however, varied considerably. The Indians who arrested Gide did so because he was an African small-businessman living not far from Magomero. The volunteer force, like the chiefs and headmen from Chiradzulu, were content to arrest 'Anguru' from the Bruce Estates. It was dangerous to be 'Anguru' and, as the earliest lists of suspects demonstrate, people rapidly switched to calling themselves 'Yao' until the authorities gave up asking the question. Meanwhile, groups of 'Anguru' made their own arrests: 'I was seized by Anguru villagers', testified a Nyanja man from Palombe, 'who said they were told by their chief to arrest all strangers'. Anyone travelling was suspect:

I went to Machilingas to see my brothers there with my wife so I was coming back by night and I came to Bombwe's village and there people seized me and they tied me up. I was with my cloth and they took it off. I don't know where my wife has gone, perhaps she has been eaten by hyenas. I don't know anything about the war.²²

It was no protection to remain at home while the volunteer force burned 'Anguru' villages. Yet to run away was proof of guilt: fifty-one cases taken at a sitting in Zomba were charged with fleeing from the askari hunting Chilembwe and each man got six month's imprisonment. Gradually, though, a pattern began to emerge. 'We were arrested in our village by Yaos because we are Christians', became the commonest of statements. A key document at the trial was the War Roll, the list of people present in Chilembwe's church the night of the rising. A key witness in identifying Christians was Aida Chlembwe (whose pathetic statement, 'I do not know why he wanted to kill the white people. I lived quite contentedly' is further evidence of her husband's privacy). In the event, the vast majority of those found guilty and sentenced to death or to long terms of imprisonment with hard labour or lashes were members of Chlembwe's church. The vast majority of these were also Anguru. No declared Mohammedan was found guilty at Zomba although there were several Yao

22. M.N.A., COM 6/3/3/1 Chlembwe Rising: Judge's records, no 29. COM 6/3/4/1 Chlembwe Rising: Magistrate's court, nos 23, 28, 30, 43, 54, 57, 65, 66, 67, 98, 140, 219, 282, 305, 314, 316, 317, 325, 326, 476, 479, 484, 486, 549, 556, 557, 558, 563, 569, 591, 600 and 630.

Christians sentenced and one Yao 'non-Christian' who had worked for Chilembwe as a carpenter. Except for the members of the Church of Christ in Zomba, no other Christians were found guilty.²³

These conclusions were paralleled at higher governmental level where matters also initially got out of hand. Governor 'Whisky' Smith's first reaction, like that of A. L. Bruce himself, had been to blame 'Christianised natives'. But panic apparently originating in the telegraph office as dramatic cables flashing to and fro ('Short of defence but we will do our best') quickly led him to believe in a wide-scale rebellion. Portuguese troops arrived from Tete to protect Limbe but Smith, claiming that the 'Mohammedan chiefs' were involved and that the rising indicated that 'far reaching causes are at work and widespread dissatisfaction', asked the colonial office for a further contingent of troops from India. By the middle of February, however, it was necessary to backpeddle somewhat. The burning of villages on the Magomero estate was interfering with the tax collection. The seizure by Midima planters of John Gray Kufa's cattle and the burning of his property before he had been put on trial had worrying legal implications, and the reports that the 'Anguru' were massively departing for Mozambique also caused disquiet. Though Smith continued to insist that 'there were very few natives in the district who were entirely ignorant of the proposed insurrection', he began to acquit some of the Yao chiefs of involvement, notably Masanjala, Onga and Kadewere, and he accepted the results of the Zomba trials: 'a large number of cases have been those of Anguru and other ignorant natives misled by Chilembwe'.²⁴

The official enquiry of June 1915 continued the process of delimitation. Spokesmen for the planters blamed the missionaries, especially the protestants. The missionaries replied by talking of the rigours of their catechism classes and they emphasised the dangers of Chilembwe's style of teaching and preaching. In stressing the churches' essential loyalty the missionaries had impressive support from the Africans questioned by the commission, including not just Kadewere and the headmen from the Bruce Estates but also Bismark the Blantyre businessman, Stephen Kundecha and Harry Kwambiri of the Church of Scotland and Robertson Namate of the Zomba secretariat. Though they voiced complaints, largely ignored by the commissioners, about the treatment of labourers on estates, about the general conduct of whites, and about particular issues such as the labour certificate and the speed of court hearings, they were united in insisting on the common interest of missionaries and the administration.

23. Ibid, nos 156-275 (51 cases). COM 6/3/2/3 Chilembwe Rising: War roll. S10/1/2 Chilembwe Rising: Statement of Aida Chilembwe.

24. P.R.O., C.O. 525/61 Smith to C.O. 27/1/15, 29/1/15, 3/2/15, 20/2/15, 8/5/15, and 6/9/15, also Cypher telegram, Quelimane, 26/1/15, interrupted telegram to Shire Highlands Railway Co., 26/1/15 and A. L. Bruce to McDiarmid 26/1/15.

As Stephen Kundecha put it, remembering that members of the Blantyre mission had accompanied Johnston's askari against Kawinga and Chikumbu, 'it is a general belief among the natives here that the "Adzungu wa Boma cannot make war without the missionaries"'. They say that they are they who pray to God for them for their good success'. The rising, then, according to African opinion tested by the commission, was not 'a Native rising' but 'a rising of John Chilembwe'.²⁵

None of this would have been sufficient, however, without some cause for the rising being postulated. Here the enquiry took a revealing course. Blaming Chilembwe himself for this blend of political and religious teaching, it also blamed unsatisfactory conditions on the Bruce Estates and the 'unduly harsh' regime of W. J. Livingstone, the manager.

William Jervis Livingstone is a difficult man to defend. As early as 1901 he was fined for 'aggravated assault' on a man called Sousa, a chained prisoner in Zomba jail who threatened him. There was abundant and convincing testimony from fellow planters at the 1915 enquiry that Livingstone had frequently beaten his field workers and domestic servants on very little provocation, and Hetherwick threw in the tit-bit that he had made improper advances to John Gray Kufa's niece. Oral testimony to this day abounds with his cruelties, reaching high levels of literary inspiration with the widespread story that *Listonia* used to attend funerals, beating the corpse with his walking stick to ensure that the man was dead and was not simply evading *thangata*. There were at the time, however, some voices raised in his defence. Sharpe wrote that he 'looked upon him as one of my oldest friends in Nyasaland, as well as being the foremost planter in the Protectorate'. Several of the Yao headmen from the Bruce Estates testified that Livingstone had distributed food from his home and in the villages in times of famine, and one of them, Liwonde, insisted when dismissed by the commission on staying behind to ask the question 'What reason had I to rise against my master?' The most eloquent and passionate defence, though, is a letter from Kathy Livingstone, his wife, protesting vehemently about the 'libels' in the commission's report:

I can see him now a few days before his death bending over a man who had been cruelly stabbed and brought to our verandah, staunching his wounds and supporting him while he gave him food to eat from his own table. I can see him that same week getting up at dawn, to carry into Zomba on his bicycle a native who had been bitten by a snake. I can see him during a year of famine passing many sleepless nights not knowing where to find food to feed not only the workers but their dependents.

25. M.N.A., COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence—evidence of Rev Stephen Kundecha, Rev Harry Kwambiri, Robertson Namate, Bismark, Kadewere, Malinda, Kalino, Mpotola, Mwalimu, and Moffat Kanchanda, also missionaries and planters *passim*.

On this occasion, after having spent some hundreds of pounds of the Trust's funds, buying rice at 5d a lb, and groundnuts at £14 a ton, he approached the government for the purchase of rice and maize. They could not supply him although loads of rice were lying at Fort Johnston and maize was being eaten by weevil at Mlanje. I can see him coming into my store and taking some bags of rice which I had bought for my boys. I remonstrated saying we could not afford to be so charitable and he replied 'Well! we cannot see these poor wretches hungry so long as we have a little food to give them'. Not only did he feed men on the Estate, he fed many who came from Boma and other lands for he had not the heart to turn them away.²⁶

What is interesting about this defence is not that there is anything inherently improbable about what is being claimed. Livingstone's actual character is almost as wrapped in myth as Chilembwe's, but it is not difficult to imagine him being quick-tempered, violent, generous and passionate by turns; no one who has studied the behaviour of *prazo*-holders in Mozambique will find anything odd about this Nyasaland equivalent. What is significant is that the defence is mounted in the same terms as the attack. Livingstone was not, as the commission claimed, a bad 'master' but an unusually good 'master'. The notion that the master-servant, patron-client, landowner-peasant, chief-subject relationship is at the very heart of colonial-African society stands unchallenged. Yet this, in the broadest sense, is precisely what Chilembwe was combating with his schools, his industrial projects, his self-help schemes and his resentment over the labour-certificate issue. As Hynde put it to the commissioners, 'this country is agricultural and there is no room for highly educated natives'. The same point was made with exquisite banality in the exchange which concluded the testimony of Wallace-Ross, the planter from Njuli who had provided the most vivid anecdotes of Livingstone's violence:

Q. You find that the natives do nothing for nothing and very little for sixpence?

A. Yes.

Q. You treat them as children?

A. Yes.

Q. You expect a man's work from him?

A. Of course I do.²⁷

26. M.N.A. S1/3008/23 Chilembwe Rising: Kathy Livingstone's reply (typescript, n.d.). COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence, evidence of Wallace-Ross, Mptoloa, Kalino and Mwalimu. P.R.O., 525/62 Sharpe to Mrs Livingstone 20/7/15 and 525/66 statement by A. Hetherwick (n.d.). C.A.T. 24/8/01. O.T. Interviews at Bowadi 22/7/82 and Komiha 19/7/82 etc.

27. M.N.A., COM 6/2/1/1 Chilembwe Rising: Oral evidence—evidence of Wallace-Ross.

Within six months of the killings at Magomero, the colonial administration had persuaded itself that the rising was much less widespread than originally feared, that it posed no serious challenge to the structures of colonial society, and that the paternalism which lay at the heart of the system was appropriate both to the economy and to the general temperament and political culture of the African population.

It was Scott, the legal spokesman for Bruce Estates, who provided the most cutting comment on this: 'what would have been said in Great Britain', he asked, 'if it had been announced that the majority of the commission appointed to enquire into the Irish Rising consisted of Dublin Castle officials and a government contractor?'²⁸

IV

Meanwhile, these explanations of the rising were being overtaken by events which themselves helped to condition which explanations were acceptable. In April 1915, Wade, the new sub-resident at Chiradzulu, reported that the chiefs had been very cooperative in getting labour out to repair roads. It was part of their courtship but was still something of a surprise. Two years earlier, one of his many predecessors had been reprimanded for forgetting that 'Blantyre district is not Angoniland' and for using askari for labour recruitment, a 'perfectly harmless move which in any other district would be perfectly normal' but which 'here provides all the material for a full-grown scandal—exaggeration by natives and europeans, reports to Zomba and a deuce of a bother'. Since then there had been little road-making and even the police lines at the *boma* awaited construction. It was decided to seize the opportunity of the chiefs' goodwill and to proceed, years in advance of elsewhere in Nyasaland, with the implementation of parts of the 1912 District Administration (Native) Ordinance (DANO). This Ordinance made provision for the appointment in administrative areas of principal headmen and subordinate village headmen to whom would be delegated minor responsibilities in the general conduct and welfare of village life and in keeping the resident informed of births, deaths, crimes, disputes and disturbances, and immigration. The village headmen had the additional duty of 'allocating village gardens and pasturage' under the resident's direction. DANO represented, in short, a first step towards indirect rule.²⁹

Before it could be implemented, however, the 'villages' had to be created. Complaints from Chiradzulu had noted that houses were 'scattered in twos and threes all about the place', making it difficult to collect

28. M.N.A., S1/3008/23 Chilembwe Rising, J. Scott to Chief Secy, Zomba, 27/7/16.

29. M.N.A., N.S.B. 2/1/1 Moggridge to Cruise 29/4/13. N.S.B. 7/3/2 Report for April 1915. Orders in Council, Ordinances, Proclamations, Rules & Orders Etc. Promulgated in the Nyasaland Protectorate (Zomba, n.d.), B42-44.

taxes, to detect crime, to protect trees, to control immigration and to keep good order generally. It was decided that houses were to be 'concentrated' into settlements of not less than twenty: this figure, at a time when hut tax kept housing to a minimum and when it was assumed in Chiradzulu district there were 2·81 persons to a hut, meant that 'villages' under village headmen were each to comprise just under 60 people. The procedure was first to explain the scheme to the chiefs and then to despatch *boma* capitões and askari round the district to 'assist the joining of small villages as far as possible'. There followed a meeting with the sub-resident at which he would 'insist on everyone consenting in my presence to any arrangements already made, appoint the headman of the new village, make enquiries, etc., about cattle, and generally satisfy myself that the arrangement is both suitable and agreeable to the natives concerned'. A particular point was made of emphasising that the scheme 'is in no way connected to the late rising'. Technically, he was right; DANO had been passed in 1912; but it was hardly surprising that no one in Chiradzulu believed him.³⁰

Wade was sceptical about the scheme from the start. The number of villages with less than twenty huts was 'extremely large' and many thousands of people had to be re-housed. They came from such diverse 'tribal' origins that it was impossible to join four adjacent small villages and appoint a headman without trouble. It meant a whole month of 'unremunerative labour' for the Africans when, because of the collective fine imposed on most of the district as a result of the rising, many men were absent in search of work. The census was being completely disrupted and it would be impossible for the time being to control the collection of hut tax. Finally, the district was chronically short of materials for house-building, especially of poles and bamboo. Wade was also dubious about the chiefs themselves. From the start he was less enamoured with them than Milthorpe had been. 'There seem to be a lot of "Thank God I am not as these Anguru" about Kadewere these days', he reported as hut concentration began, and over the next few months he writes frequently about the effects on the chiefs of the policies he was implementing. Kadewere, Chikoja and Chombe were soon suspected of exceeding their authority by conducting court cases and extorting compensation by imprisoning people; Nkalo's sons were 'known to have old-fashioned and discredited views on the subject of the chief's powers'; the enlargement of villages was producing in some headmen 'a corresponding inflation of their estimate of their own importance'; and there was friction between village headmen and the chiefs who were thrown together by an 'accident of geography' rather than by anything in their traditions.³¹

30. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/2 Report for June 1915.

31. Ibid, Reports for June, Sept and Nov 1915. N.S.B. 7/3/3 Report for August 1916.

But while Wade's instincts and observation pointed him in one direction, official policy and the logic of events led him in another. In August, he was instructed to find 1000 *tenga-tenga* carriers to transport war goods to Fort Johnston. It struck him as an impossible demand and the suggestion that he should ask the chiefs seemed wildly optimistic. To his delight they furnished 900 men in two days and offered him more. That same month, the 'Anguru' began migrating from Chiradzulu, moving on to the private estates including Bruce Estates or back to Mulanje and to Mozambique. Wade, who was beginning to see virtue in the chiefs, pooh-poohed the notion that they were responsible blaming instead the 'injustice of public opinion in blaming [the Anguru] for the war'. In November, there was an incident. Nkalo, a 'particularly strong Mohammedan', requested the use of askari to help with hut concentration. Later that morning, Wade received a scribbled note: 'We have war here. They want to beat us. Now they're taking knives and sticks'. Wade's swift response in publicly flogging Livelwa, the headman of the 'Anguru' village concerned, was approved by Moggridge: 'in time of war and within a year of the Chilembwe rising it is only desirable to come down instantly and heavily on any nonsense such as you describe'. By the end of the year, Wade had despatched 2300 *tenga-tenga* carriers and, the chiefs being 'cooperative', he provided 800 more in January 1916. There was further trouble in February, for, while Chombe and Likoswe were able to recruit carriers without help, Kadewere and Chikoja needed the assistance of the police. Meanwhile, some of the widows and sons of Chilembwe's supporters had begun to re-settle at Mbombwe, and there were rumours of a camp of 'John Chilembwe-ites' across the Mozambique border. On the last night of February 1916 rumours again spread that 'spearsmen had been seen hiding' and the whites at Magomero spent the night blockaded in the main office. Wade was suddenly nervous. He arrested four people on a charge of 'being Christians' and then had to let them go because they were breaking no law. If trouble comes to the district, he reported, it will be from

discharged capitões, houseboys, mission teachers etc., returned emigrants to South Africa, professional criminals and generally natives who have become dissatisfied with the state of life in which they were born, but are not prepared to improve it by honest industry.³²

The immediate pressure of events in Wade's own sub-district had pushed him towards the same conclusions as the commission of enquiry.³³

32. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/3 Report for March 1916.

33. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/2, Report of Aug 1915, and Wade to Moggridge 17/8/15, 11/10/15, and 4/12/15. N.S.B. 7/3/3, Reports of Feb and March 1916, and Wade to Moggridge 11/3/16 and 8/7/16. N.S.B. 2/1/1 Moggridge to Wade 12/10/15.

This left him, though, with no possible allies except the chiefs. Wade could read his own signals and his language changes. 'Owing to the energetic cooperation of the chiefs', he reports, 'hut concentration has been largely accomplished'. He hopes that 'some honest and influential heathen or Mohameddan will take a fancy to one of the Chilembwe widows' in which case he could be recognised as a headman. He regrets that 'the number of influential Yao headmen' in parts of Nkalo's area is 'unfortunately small' and that the 'Anguru' are anticipating 'a golden age of republicanism'. He becomes, in fact, impatient to proceed to the next stage of DANO, the selection of just five principal headmen for the district. The chiefs, too, could read signals and they began again to call at the residency. In July 1916, Wade received visits from Kadewere (three times), Onga (three times), Malika (three times), Mpama (once) and Chikoja (four times), all of them are coming for 'talk and an afternoon at the "bar"'. Kadewere in particular was full of interesting ideas: taking a selection of blue gum plants, he 'told me he intended to select from his villages a gang of youths and old men who as their age prevented them from doing any military *thangata* would be required by him to plant and look after a much larger plantation than he had previously attempted'. Meanwhile, the 'Anguru' continued to 'show their aversion to living in properly controlled and supervised' villages (reading this over, Wade had second thoughts: he struck out 'supervised' and replaced it with 'settled'). He continued to deny that they were being 'oppressed' in any way, attributing their emigration to a 'vague nomadic instinct' which made it impossible for them to live in any one place for very long. In writing this Wade knew perfectly well that virtually all the 6000 carriers supplied from Chiradzulu during the war were 'Anguru'. He was aware that the majority of those affected by hut-concentration were 'Anguru' and that the power of the newly appointed village headmen to allocate land use put all immigrants in their power. He went so far as to report that the 'Anguru' preferred to bring their cases to him, rather than to the Yao chiefs whom they distrusted, even though he knew the chiefs had not yet been given the powers to hear cases. But the balance of sympathy had swung considerably since December 1914. In December 1917, Wade despatched 1151 'Anguru' to Captain Costley-White, all of them supplied by the chiefs at four days' notice for six months' service as carriers. In a repeat of the Sinderam and Walker scandal of 1900, 44 of them were dead by January and a large number of the others had run away 'in a state of grave debility'. Wade's monthly report notes simply that they 'ran away from their work' but that the chiefs and headmen were 'loyal and amicable'.³⁴

34. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/3 Reports for July & Oct 1916, Dec 1917 and Jan & March 1918. N.S.B. 7/3/2 Wade to Moggridge 4/12/15.

Then there was a bonus, a development so unanticipated that Wade nowhere connects it with the shift in power over which he had been presiding. In April 1916, exactly one year after hut concentration began, Wade noted that tobacco was being cultivated as a cash crop 'as Chikoja's people have begun to emulate the enterprise of their neighbours on Mr Hinde's land'. The new crop was dark-fired tobacco, cured in the sun or over wood fires without the need for the flue barns required for the bright Virginia tobacco which constituted the bulk of Nyasaland's export crop. Hynde of the Blantyre & East Africa Co. introduced dark-fired tobacco as a tenant crop on the company's estate in Chiradzulu and within a year it had become a new cash crop not just for Chikoja's area but in Mpama's and Kanyenda's as well. No reliable production figures are available until the mid-1920s (starting with 248.80 tons from African growers in Chiradzulu in 1924), but descriptions of the crop which, in March 1919, was 'unusually large' and 'of very good quality', make it clear that this was a development of great importance not just to the district but to the Nyasaland economy as a whole; by 1930, dark-fired tobacco grown and cured by Africans throughout the protectorate represented 73.5 per cent of Nyasaland's tobacco exports. If the stimulus came from Hynde, however, it was the redistribution of power in Chiradzulu which provided the opportunity. Hut concentration involved a change in land use with the newly-appointed headman responsible for its distribution. 'Anguru' labour was available on *akapolo* terms. The long over-due abolition of the labour certificate provided chiefs and headmen who were responsible for tax collection with the perfect means of mobilising labour on their own behalf. By April 1919, the district was overrun with white buyers, prepared to pay up to one shilling per pound and offering advances to individual growers plus the capital to build curing barns.³⁵

As this indicates, the very success of the crop proved the chiefs' and headmen's temporary undoing. It was impossible for them to maintain control of labour once that labour became profitable to others, and the purchasers of tobacco as well as of maize and vegetables tried constantly to deal directly with the growers. When they formed price rings, the chiefs could only grumble to the resident. The 'Anguru', too, within the framework of their overall subjection, had certain options, of moving back to Mulanje or on to Zomba or to the private estates where 'new tenants have the advantage of being given the best land for their gardens and where there is a plentiful supply of timber'. They could even go to South Africa or Southern Rhodesia without fear of reprisal for the chiefs and headmen,

35. M.N.A., N.S.B. 7/3/3 Reports for April 1916 and March & April 1919. District Book, Chiradzulu. COM 7/2/2/1 Tobacco Commission, *Memo. Prepared by Dept of Agriculture*. 12405 19.3.7 1568, History of the Blantyre & East Africa Co.

unlike the landlords of the private estates, had no powers of eviction. By 1923, it was once again being said:

drastic measures must be adopted to bring the population under control and separate out what is at present simply a collection of beings with no tribal thought or custom and without consideration for his neighbours, simply living in the district as long as it pleases and then moves on to another part [sic]. I can see nothing but disaster facing the present policy, and marvel how many chiefs were allowed to become established in this district to the elimination and respect where it was due.³⁶

Meanwhile, chiefs and headmen began to find themselves responsible for enforcing government policies on afforestation and on soil erosion which were not only unpopular with their subjects but really of little direct profit to themselves. The creation of the Native Tobacco Board in 1926 to supervise the production of tobacco as well as of other cash crops further restricted opportunities for the chiefs to control 'Anguru' labour directly (though indirect means were still available: evidence presented to the Tobacco commission in 1938 noted that 'when we first started some of the headmen waited for the garden to be trenched and then said "you cannot have that field this year"' and gave them another, but that practice has pretty well ceased'.)³⁷

They retained, however, two considerable advantages. The first was that 'Anguru' immigrants continued to pour into the district. On the Mozambique side new plantations were established in the 1920s, of tea in Milange, tobacco in Ile and sizal in Lugella, all with the right to recruit labour under the 1899 code, and in 1926 Sena Sugar Estates secured labour concessions in Milange, Lomwe and Lugella *prazos*. These developments provided fresh reasons for emigration to Nyasaland and the process continued after 1930 with the abolition of the *prazo* system, the arrival of Portuguese administrators and *chefes do posto* in the 'Anguru' homelands, and the rise of the Gurue tea industry. Not all the new migrants settled in Chiradzulu district. Zomba was an increasingly popular destination and the sinking of bore holes on the Palombe plain made possible a much denser pattern of settlement in Mulanje district. Moreover, the effects of world recession on the private estates were such that many went over to tenant production of tobacco with *thangata* being levied in crops rather than labour, and the availability of land under such arrangements continued to attract new tenants. Enough settled in Chiradzulu, however, to maintain advantages to the chiefs and headmen they approached for permission to

36. M.N.A., N.S.D. 2/1/1 Chiradzulu Annual Report for 1922/23. N.S.B. 7/3/4 Assistant Res, Chiradzulu to Resident Blantyre 29/3/21.

37. M.N.A., COM 7/2/1/1 Tobacco Commission: Oral evidence—evidence of Bartlett & Barnes.

settle. For the new immigrant, the problem was to secure his first year's tax paper, a paper carrying a chief's name as evidence of residence in Nyasaland. With that, he could move on elsewhere, to Southern Rhodesia or South Africa, or even back to Mozambique as a migrant if he wished. The first year was the hurdle, and the price was *ganyão* labour for the chiefs and headmen. The scale of such settlement produced regular confrontations between the chiefs and the resident: in 1915 the population density in Chiradzulu had been 55 to the square mile; by 1926 it was 239.15 and by 1931, 296.77. The chiefs, however, were 'far more interested in the money they can get for their own crops' than in questions of over-population or soil erosion.³⁸

The second big advantage was the eagerness of the administration to implement the policy of indirect rule, beginning with the Shire highlands. In Mulanje in 1922, chiefs complained to the resident that they had little control over 'Anguru' immigrants. They were told 'they could acquire dignity by the use of clean apparel, by reporting offences and by sending idlers to work'. The context of this discussion was a fall-off in tax receipts and a labour shortage on the tea estates, but the resident promised to help; he 'would give them power and make big chiefs of them', at which they thanked him for his words 'which they said had given them joy'. An amended version of DANO was passed in 1924. 'Village areas' were to be created by the resident and village headmen appointed with duties similar to those marked out in 1912. Now, however, each headman was empowered to hold courts for civil and criminal cases, and he was to be assisted by up to 10 village councillors appointed by the resident. Principal headmen, appointed by the Governor, and section councillors, appointed by the provincial commissioner, were to administer 'sections' made up of 'village areas'.³⁹

Despite the air of bureaucratic unreality conveyed by the language of this ordinance, the powers delegated were real ones. Principal headmen in particular were to benefit in a number of ways. They could hear cases referred to them by the village headmen and could charge a fee; they could arrange marriages and administer divorce, with profound implications for the rights of women; they were responsible for tax collection which in practice conferred advantages in the control of labour; they issued beer licenses which brought the major industry for women under their jurisdiction; they controlled afforestation, a significant power in tobacco growing districts but also involving house building and much local industry; and they

38. Vail & White, *Capitalism & Colonialism* chapters 4 & 5. *Nyasaland Protectorate, Report on the Census of 1926* (Zomba 1926), and *Report on the Census of 1931* (Zomba, 1931). M.N.A., District Books for Mulanje and Chiradzulu. N.S.D. 2/1/1 Chiradzulu Annual Report for 1926/27.

39. M.N.A., District Book for Milanje, report on District Council meeting of 3/1/22. *Ordinances of the Nyasaland Protectorate for the Year Ended 31/12/1924*, no 11 of 1924.

acquired for the first time clearly defined powers over the village headmen, with consequences for the allocation of land. The position of principal headman was obviously one worth fighting for and in Chiradzulu in the 1920s competition was strong as the applicants staked out their claims. Tactics varied. Courtesy calls on the resident and cooperation with his demands remained a key method but with a new ingredient, for the residents were beginning to be interested in 'tribal' history and a bewildering series of versions of the relative powers in pre-colonial times of Mpama, Malika, Chikoja, Kadewere and the others began to be recorded in the District Book and in Annual Reports. Mpama went so far as to accept the chairmanship of the Chiradzulu District Native Association founded in 1929 by Daniel Malekebu, who had taken over Chilembwe's mission in 1926, in the hope that the association could be made a vehicle for his claims to the paramountship. Geographical accident played a part; with only five principal headmanships available, Malika stood little chance unless Mpama's claims could be discredited. But the biggest factor was 'Anguru' settlement. When the five lucky principal headmen were chosen late in 1929, Mpama was selected because his version of history had prevailed and Nchemba was chosen by Bruce Estates to administer the Chiradzulu portion of their land holdings. The other three were Kadewere, Nkalo and Likoswe, all of whom had come to prominence because of the large number of 'Anguru' villages under their control. In Nkalo's case, 90 per cent of the population he administered was 'Anguru', while the number of villages in Kadewere's section had risen from 22 in 1918 to 83 in 1928, making him by then the biggest chief in the district.

All five were believed at the time to be Yao and Mohammedan. They were issued with robes, fezes, and other insignia of office (though there was something wrong with the design and Mpama complained he looked like a *machila*-man). Among their first requests was that when concentrating villages they should be allowed to separate 'Mohammedans' from 'pagans'.⁴⁰

V

One aspect of the imposition of indirect rule in the Shire highlands between 1915 and 1930 was, quite clearly, an alliance with Islam. Within months of the Chilembwe rising the administration had suppressed its first suspicions that the Yao chiefs of Chiradzulu and Mulanje might have

40. For orders issued by the new Principal Headmen and for local population figures, see M.N.A., District Books vols 1 for Chiradzulu, Mulanje and Zomba. See also District Council meetings for Chiradzulu (in District Book) 12/8/29 and 26/7/32. N.S.D. 2/1/1, Chiradzulu Annual Report for 1926. N.S. 1/3/5, Chiradzulu District Native Association, minutes of meeting of 12/11/29 and Barnes to Senior Prov Com, Blantyre, 5/2/35.

been involved and had come to lay the blame squarely on Chilembwe's Christians. Costley-White, the Zomba resident at the time of the rising, made the point simply when, after hanging Makwangwala for complicity, he appointed his brother Kimu as a village headman, noting 'Kimu is a Mohammedan and is useful as a counterpoise to the followers of the late John Chilembwe'. It was Costley-White who, the following November, was despatched by Governor Smith to Fort Johnston to investigate rumours of a letter from German East Africa calling on Mohammedans in Nyasaland and Mozambique to rise against the British and Portuguese. Costley-White's report confirmed the 'loyalty of Mohammedans', and Smith that year made a special point of paying his respects to the Islamic community by attending the festival of Eid at the conclusion of Ramadan.⁴¹

The following year, Smith held a reception at government house to celebrate Eid. By then, the Colonial Office was offering to publish documents captured in German East Africa dealing with the suppression of Islam by the Germans. Smith could see no need for this: the 'Yao tribes' had furnished plenty of men for military service and, as Mohammedans, had 'proved in the last two years their loyalty to the King as fully as the vast population of their co-religionists in India'. However, he had been approached at the Eid reception by one of the Yao chiefs urging the need for a mosque in Zomba, the colonial capital and headquarters of the army, and urging too that all Islamic communities in Nyasaland should be brought under the control of the Sultan of Zanzibar. He referred, reported Smith impressively, 'to the lack of authority governing the action of Mohammedans and he very pertinently observed that the result might be in the end the creation of a Mohammedan John Chilembwe!' The Colonial Office, with an eye on the Scottish missionaries, was not responsive.⁴²

The alliance with the chiefs, however, remained intact and began to be re-formulated in different terms. Being Mohammedan was not necessarily quite the same thing as being 'Yao'. The process by which notions of a 'Yao' identity could be separated from its involvement with Islam was illustrated as early as 1894 in the *Gazette*. Writing of Mohameddians in Mulanje, Peter Dupeyron of the St Francis Xavier mission notes:

They call themselves children of light and sons of the Most High, and look on all others—black, white or yellow—as belonging to the race of dogs. If asked what they have done to deserve such eminence, they say 'We do not eat pork, we do not wring a fowl's neck, we say a lot of prayers to Muhammed. Isn't that enough? What more do you want?

41. P.R.O., C.O. 525/63 Smith to C.O. 15/11/15.

42. P.R.O., C.O. 525/69 Smith to C.O. 16/10/16 and reply 6/8/17.

Writing of precisely the same people as Ajawa (Yao), however, he says:

Amongst Central African natives, there is none more intelligent than the Ajawa. They may be unscrupulous and callous, but still the intelligence is there, though it may be intelligence gone wrong.⁴³

There is, of course, nothing very surprising in the discovery that at a time when the Yao chiefs were the main enemies of British rule they were spoken of with a mixture of abuse and reluctant respect. Or that once they had been defeated, a fresh assessment was required in which racial, ethnic and religious categories were constantly manipulated to accomodate all possible attitudes. It was after the Chilembwe rising, however, when the main enemy of colonial paternalism had been discovered in the missionised native and when the possibility of a formal alliance with Islam had been turned down, that notions of ethnic identity came to dominate colonial discourse.

Reading official documents from 1915 onwards it is hard to avoid the feeling that the Shire highlands were being administered with reference to categories existing only in the minds of the administrators, but becoming realities when internalised by Africans as part of the process of collaboration or survival. That they *did* become realities, as the bases of production and bureaucracy, has been demonstrated: the 'Anguru' did briefly come to call themselves Anguru and the authority of 'principal headmen' over their 'sections' made up of 'village areas' became a real authority. One wonders at times, though, who was playing a game with whom? When Nchemba was chosen by Bruce Estates as the principal headman of their Chiradzulu section, he was described as 'Yao' and as 'a pleasant man well liked by people'. Two years later it was noted that 'he has recently started to drink to excess' and as the decline continued he had to be lectured on the need to maintain his authority by 'firmness'. It was too late, however, to save his reputation; he had been discovered to be a 'Nyanja', and not long afterwards he was 'vain', 'often drunk' and unwilling to take any initiative. Did he become a 'Nyanja' because he drank or did he drink because he was a 'Nyanja'? It is difficult to be sure for, in fact, all discussion about the district proceeds on the assumption that the population is divided between 'Yao' and 'Anguru'. Each annual report, making use of the latest census figures, begins by observing there are 40,000 Anguru, 21,000 Yao and 13,500 Nyanja. But the Nyanja have no further existence save as the remnants of the people the Yao originally dispossessed. Left over from the past they have no significant present: the battle lines are between law and disorder, 'Yao' and 'Anguru'. With such arbitrary categories it is scarcely

43. B.C.A.G. 4/6/94.

surprising that when the administration became aware that Kadewere was unpopular with his people 'due in great measure to his having been too loyal to us during the 1915 troubles', the resident should have found comfort in the rumour that he was really an 'Anguru' passing for 'Yao'.⁴⁴

What the administration was searching for at bottom was some analogue of the English class system. The principal headmen and village headmen were, after all, being incorporated into the colonial bureaucracy as functionaries, some way down the ladder from the sub-residents but nevertheless having to display a little of the same natural ability to govern. The problem, given the masses of the Africans all remarkably alike in their poverty, was how to distinguish which ones were the gentlemen. With Christianity threatening to produce only an African bourgeoisie and with the public embrace of Islam a political impossibility, the way was left open for the elaboration of ethnic theories of differentiation.

A text which illustrates the process is S. S. Murray's *A Handbook to Nyasaland* (1922 ed.). Murray comments on the vagueness of such terms as 'Anguru' which he explains (wrongly) as merely a Yao word for the speakers of unintelligible languages. The 'Anguru', he explains, are a number of different peoples loosely allied in the Makua-Lomwe group but bearing separate designations (Atakwani, Akokola, Amihavani, etc) referring to different districts of origin over the border; and he is mildly sarcastic about how, when different groups were brought together in work gangs, the difficulties of interpretation gave rise to the sage dictum "The Anguru don't know their own language". Similarly with respect to the Yao, Murray comments, due to inter-marriage which has robbed them of their 'finer features', the 'majority of so-called Yaos' in the Shire highlands 'have little claim to the name'. However, this recognition of the lack of ethnic homogeneity in southern Nyasaland does not prevent him from talking of specifically 'Anguru' and 'Yao' traits. The 'Anguru', he claims, 'are rapidly losing their tribal and social characteristics' and 'are represented among the idle and criminal classes to a disproportionate extent'. The 'Yao', on the other hand, are 'intelligent and quick' making 'excellent servants' while 'as soldiers they have proved of inestimable value'. They also speak 'perhaps the finest of all Central African languages'. Unfortunately, and as it were a by-product of their intelligence and fine features, the Yao are 'poor cultivators of the soil'.⁴⁵

As this implies, the 'Yao' were seen as being more like whites than any other peoples of the Shire highlands. They lived in 'square houses' and cultivated 'personal cleanliness'. It was felt they understood a certain man-to-man equality of address: complaints from the chiefs at district

44. M.N.A., Chiradzulu District Book vol 1 contains regular re-assessments of chiefs. See also N.S.D. 2/1/1 Chiradzulu Annual Reports for 1931 and 1936.

45. S. S. Murray, *A Handbook of Nyasaland* (Zomba, 1922), 45-7, 55-7, 95.

council meetings were often answered with the comment that, just as the Yao had seized the land from the Mang'anja, so the British had seized it from the Yao. Some of this superiority could be put down to the advantages of 'Arab influence'. But they were also a people with a history, in marked contrast to others who had only customs and folklore. Yohanna B. Abdullah's *The Yaos* was published in chiYao and English by the government printing office in Zomba in 1919. Abdullah's aim was to 'write a book all about the customs of we Yaos, so that we remind ourselves whence we sprang and of our beginnings as a nation'. He showed all the necessary skills of later Malawian historians in circumventing difficult issues: most of the colonial wars, for example, take place on the Mozambique side of the border, and as for the slave trade:

Of these slaves, some they took to the coast to buy trade-goods with them, others they kept at home to hoe the gardens, build houses and do other village work. They did not illtreat or beat them, nor did they make them hoe unassisted; for the old Yaos were merciful. All this ill-treatment and overworking was introduced when the coast people and Arabs came to Yaoland, in the old days it was not so.⁴⁶

However, if some of the details of names, places and migrations were a little confusing to the English reader, there could be no mistaking the heartfelt emotion of his repeated refrain: 'This was in the old days, the good old days which will never return'.

Seventeen years later in his annual report for Chiradzulu district, the resident K. Barnes produced an even more serviceable account of Yao history, also based on oral testimony. The Yao had their origins in Mozambique as family units or Mbumba, small matrilineal communities living often many miles apart. Under the pressure of danger from the Portuguese and Arabs of the east coast, they coalesced into larger communities living under chiefs who were responsible for organising their security. The chief who led in war came from the largest of the various Mbumba which had amalgamated, but the allocation of land remained the responsibility of the head of the Mbumba where the 'coalition' had actually taken place. A later stage, as war intensified, was the formation of still larger communities, the family groups thus evolving into the 'tribe' or sub-sections of the tribe under paramount chiefs. At this stage of development, which coincided with the migrations into Nyasaland, there were thus three levels of power: the paramount chiefs, the subordinate chiefs, and the village Mbumba, usually headed by the nephew of the village 'mother'. Although the paramount was essentially a military figure, his position 'rested largely on his reputation for fairness'. No Yao paramount ever had

46. Y. Abdullah, *The Yaos* (Zomba, 1919) preface and 31.

the power of a Zulu or Ngoni chief: if a Zulu chief was like Caesar, the Yao paramounts were more like English prime ministers! The Yao, then, were a tribe with a history; they had evolved through the proper stages into something like a nation. The problem in dealing with them was that this fact had not been understood by the colonial authorities.

The policy pursued by us till quite recently has been to break the power of the big chiefs and has led naturally to a regression—a detribalising—back to the old loose system of the 'Mbumba'. And now we have altered our policy and are trying to undo what we have done and return to the system we originally found.⁴⁷

After writing this section of the report Barnes went on leave and it was left to his successor A. C. Kirby to investigate the history of the 'Anguru'. These, it transpired, had evolved in the opposite direction. Originally united under the chieftancy of Mwatunga, the tribe had disintegrated into family groups taking their names from their relationship to Mwatunga's respective wives. Thus the 'Anguru' were no longer a 'tribal unit'. What Kirby's investigations had revealed to him was that the term 'Anguru' was a fiction, this discovery by a twist of colonial thinking being adduced as fresh proof of their inferiority.

There was, though, a serious problem over the 'Anguru'. Nyasaland was an agricultural country and, as Murray had noted, colonial wisdom declared that the Yao were not good cultivators of the soil. There were some estate owners to whom by the 1930s this was no longer a problem. As the world recession cut commodity prices to such a point that even crops levied in lieu of *thangata* were no longer profitable, many estates were abandoned. Other owners tried to ride out the recession but found themselves afflicted with a resident 'Anguru' population which was rapidly consuming their one remaining asset, that is, the land itself. As J. Tennett put it, with all the aggrieved innocence of a man entirely responsible for his position:

The whole of my land has been deforested by these Anguru and there is not a single indigenous tree left apart from those growing on the banks of streams, the cutting of which I have forbidden. In a very short period the fertility of this land will either have been exhausted or washed away and will become desert. These Anguru will then move of their own accord, just like locusts and will possibly go back to Portuguese territory whence they came.⁴⁸

47. M.N.A., N.S.D. 2/1/1, Chiradzulu Annual Report for 1936.

48. M.N.A., S1/411/33, J. Tennett to Cholo D. C. 4/11/35.

'Originally', Tennett continued, apparently unaware that he was spoiling his case, 'I settled these Anguru on my land for a definite purpose—i.e. a reserve labour supply'. Now, however, in 1935, he sought to evict them and the administration found that of 145 'trespassers' ordered to leave his Mangunda estate, 91 were youths born on the estate who had reached the age of 16. Eviction was unacceptable to the administration which would have to settle the people on crown land, also congested and also suffering the effects of the recession.

Not everyone, though, saw the matter in such terms. 'Anguru' labour remained indispensable to the tea estates of Mulanje and Thyolo. The question came up at district council meetings in Mulanje in 1931; with impeccable logic the chiefs complained that they were being rebuked for settling 'Anguru' in their villages while the tea estates were employing them by the thousands. The official reply was that 'Europeans naturally employed natives who worked hardest . . . and the Anguru were known to work harder than the other people living in the district'. This view of the 'Anguru' was given a fresh airing three years later when tax disincentives were being considered as a means of discouraging immigration. Confortzi, the leading planter from Thyolo, insisted that 'Anguru labour on the tea estates are only doing the very rough work which no Nyasaland labourers will do', this representing 75 per cent or 80 per cent of the work on tea estates'.⁴⁹ A further complication was the security issue; Chiradzulu in particular remained the flashpoint of the Protectorate and in 1939 there was dramatic confirmation of the dangers.

With the collapse of tobacco prices, Bruce Estates in 1932 abandoned plantation production and adopted the system, sanctioned by the Natives on Private Estates Ordinance of 1928, of levying rent in the form of 200 lbs of tobacco in place of *thangata* labour, the growers to be paid at fixed rates. To process this tobacco for the West African market, a handling factory was erected at the old ginnery at Magomero. From 1937 there were rumours of financial problems at Bruce Estates. The manager, Captain Kincaid-Smith, was in arrears with factory wages, was unable to pay his tenants for the tobacco they grew, and was behind with the salaries of white assistants. Matters came to a head when, after the introduction of the tobacco auction floors in 1938, African growers switched to maize as a more profitable crop. Enforcing his rights as a landlord, Kincaid-Smith dressed in his captain's uniform and, accompanied by the Zomba district commissioner, toured the estate lecturing tenants on their obligation to grow tobacco and pulling up their maize. The story spread rapidly that

49. M.N.A., L 3/20/11 Native Hut & Poll Tax: Leg. Co., Select Committee . . . appointed to consider and report what legislation if any is required to ensure the fullest possible agricultural development of the Protectorate . . . Zomba, 31/5/34. Mulanje District Book, record of District Council meeting of 14/8/31.

the administration was using the army to compel people to grow tobacco without payment. Meanwhile, Father Heraud of the Nguludi Mission, which had been burned during the Chilembwe rising, reported that members of the Watchtower church were planning a revolt:

The leaders are said to hold their meetings at a village called Matamera in Portuguese East Africa close to Mlanje mountain, near the Ruvo, Mlanje district. According to the father there is to be a 'rising' in the middle of January when several selected Europeans will be killed in the initial instance, the *big* rising coming later on in the rains when the success of the first murders will have rallied the bulk of the population on their side.⁵⁰

These correspondences—discontent on the Bruce Estates, the African Christians of Mulanje and Chiradzulu, the first January of the war—were too much for the Governor. Wishing to avoid the publicity of a deportation, he cabled Kincaid-Smith's commanding officer and hustled him from the Protectorate.

By the early 1940s, then, the 'Anguru' problem remained very much as it had been in the last week of January 1915. To some it was already clear that the only long-term solution lay in the purchase by government of the large estates, the abolition of *thangata*, and the relief of congestion in Chiradzulu, Blantyre and Thyolo by land settlement schemes. Meanwhile, public debate became extraordinarily virulent. Spokesmen for the planters who began to fear they might be displaced by 'Anguru' they had themselves settled on their land lashed out in letters to the *Nyasaland Times*. Why should Britons die, raged one, 'to make Nyasaland a safe boozing den for alien Nguru?' There was insufficient space in the paper, clamoured another, to show 'from the history of this people the steps by which they became in turn slave-trading gangsters, irregular soldiers, cringing-starving-unclothed refugees, and finally under a safe benign government: slothful, drunken and vicious'. The older colonial historiography was turned on its head: all long it had been the 'Anguru' who were the slave traders: they were 'candid bandits, their prey human flesh and blood, and having gorged like the hyenas they were they returned *ku Manguru* for the most part replete'. Anyone who doubted this statement was invited to 'ask Mr Sinderam what happened to him and his partner in 1898 . . . Mr Sinderam is still with us I am happy to say'.⁵¹

The wheel of opinion had come full circle: the former 'raw Anguru' were now the cannibals. But while the administration began to consider the question of post-war land reforms, the initiative passed into fresh hands.

50. M.N.A., GOB /G 187 A. L. Bruce Estates Ltd, Phillips to Ellis 16/12/39 and file *passim*.

51. *Nyasaland Times* (N.T.), 13/7/42 and 6/8/42

The reasoned reply to the letters in the *Nyasaland Times* ('We wonder if Mr Wright's statement that the "Anguru" are loafers can be supported by the Government or the planters') was co-ordinated by Charles M. Mlanga whose name headed a list of six signatories. Within two years, Mlanga had become first secretary general of the Nyasaland African Congress with Levi Mumba as first chairman. One of the committee members and a close associate was Lewis Bandawe who in 1943 founded the Alomwe Tribal Representative Association which successfully petitioned to have the word 'Anguru' banned as a term of offence from all official documents and replaced by the term 'Lomwe'. The 'Anguru' problem thus became the Lomwe problem. The various groups which had entered Nyasaland from Mozambique had at last become 'a tribe'. One of the tactics used in their campaign for rehabilitation was to claim that not all the Yao chiefs who invaded the Shire highlands in the 1860s had actually been Yao; some of them, like Kawinga, had been Lomwe.⁵²

Postscript, 1953

In mid-July 1953, anti-Federation disturbances which had begun in Noheu the previous May spread to Chiradzulu district. On 17 July village headman Malika, who had lost out in the competition for the post of principal headman in 1930, arranged a public meeting of the Nyasaland African Congress. The purpose was to demand that chief Mpama should be deposed. The district commissioner, who had only been appointed to Chiradzulu ten days earlier, arrested Malika. That evening and again the following day when he tried to get help to Mpama, his car was stoned. On the 20th, another meeting was arranged, this time with the intention of calling for the deposition of Nkalo. Matters quietened down for the rest of the month, while the main focus of the disturbance shifted to Thyolo district and took on an anti-*thangata* aspect with an attack on Tennett's Mangunda Estate. On 28 August, however, a large meeting of Congress was convened at Namitambo in Chiradzulu district, as part of a campaign to depose Kadewere. The district commissioner banned the meeting and called in police who made baton charges to clear the area around Kadewere's house. In the riots which followed, roads were blocked, bridges destroyed, and Mpama's house was burned down. It was October before authority was restored. The official enquiry blamed immigrants from Mozambique for the disturbances.⁵³

52. N.T. 30/7/42. See also Lewis Bandawe, *Memoirs of a Malawian* ed., B. Pachai (Blantyre, 1971), 128-29.

53. M.N.A. Chiradzulu district book vol 1.